Rain, Rain, Go Away

By Isaac Asimov

LILLIAN: There she is again, There she is, George.

GEORGE: There who is?

LILLIAN: Mrs. Sakkaro, The new neighbors, for goodness sake. Sunbathing. Always sunbathing. I wonder where her boy is. He's usually out on a nice day like this, standing in that tremendous yard of theirs and throwing the ball against the house. Did you ever see him, George?"

GEORGE: I've heard him. It's a version of the Chinese water torture. Bang on the wall, biff on the ground, smack in the hand. Bang, biff, smack, bang, biff—

LILLIAN: He's a nice boy, quiet and well-behaved. I wish Tommie would make friends with him. He's the right age, too, just about ten. I should say.

GEORGE: I didn't know Tommie was backward about making friends.

LILLIAN: Well, it's hard with the Sakkaros. They keep so to themselves. I don't even know what Mr. Sakkaro does.

GEORGE: Why should you? It's not really anyone's business what he does.

LILLIAN: It's odd that I never see him go to work.

GEORGE: No one ever sees me go to work.

LILLIAN: You stay home and write. What does he do?

GEORGE: I dare say Mrs. Sakkaro knows what Mr. Sakkaro does and is all upset because she doesn't know what I do."

LILLIAN: Oh, George. I think we should make an effort; the neighborhood should.

GEORGE: What kind of effort?

LILLIAN: To get to know them.

GEORGE: Well, didn't you, when she'd just moved in? You said you called.

LILLIAN: I said hello but, well, she'd just moved in and the house was still upset, so that's all it could be, just hello. It's been two months now and it's still nothing more than hello, sometimes. —She's so odd. She's always looking at the sky; I've seen her do it a hundred times and she's never been out when it's the least bit cloudy. Once, when the boy was out playing, she called to him to come in, shouting that it was going to rain. I happened to hear her and I thought, Oh no, wouldn't you know and me with a wash on the line, so I hurried out and, you know, it was broad sunlight. Oh, there were some clouds, but nothing, really."

GEORGE: Did it rain, eventually?

LILLIAN: Of course not. I just had to run out in the yard for nothing.

GEORGE: Well, since they're from Arizona, I dare say they don't know rainclouds from any other kind.

LILLIAN: From where?

GEORGE: From Arizona, according to Tommie. He talked to their boy, in between ball chucks, I guess, and he told Tommie they came from Arizona and then the boy was called in. At least, Tommie says in might have been Arizona, or maybe Alabama some place like that. You know Tommie and his non-total recall. But if they're that nervous about the weather, I guess it's Arizona and they don't know what to make out of a good rainy climate like ours.

LILLIAN: But why didn't you ever tell me?

GEORGE: Because Tommie only told me this morning and because I thought he must have told you already and, to tell the absolute truth, because I thought you could just manage to drag out a normal existence even if you never found out. Wow—"

LILLIAN: [looking out the window at the neighbor] I'll simply just have to make her acquaintance. She looks very nice. —Oh, look at that, George. I know she's staring at that cloud. And now she'll be going in. Honestly.

INTRODUCTION

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LILLIAN: Now, you're not doing anything tomorrow.

GEORGE: That sounds like a statement, not a question.

LILLIAN: It is a statement. We're going out with the Sakkaros to Murphy's Park. With the next-door neighbors, George. How can you never remember the name?"

GEORGE: I'm gifted. How did it happen?

LILLIAN: I just went up to their house this morning and rang the bell. I stood there, jittering, with my finger on the doorbell, till I thought that ringing the bell would be easier than having the door open and being caught standing there like a fool. She was sweet as she could be. Invited me in, knew who I was, said she was so glad I had come to visit. You know."

GEORGE: And you suggested we go to Murphy's Park.

LILLIAN: I thought if I suggested something that would let the children have fun, it would be easier for her to go along with it. She wouldn't want to spoil a chance for her boy. You should see her home. I have never seen any place so spotless.

GEORGE: If you get to know her, then, she'll be setting you impossible standards and you'll have to drop her in self-defense.

LILLIAN: Her kitchen was so spanking clean you just couldn't believe she ever used it. I asked for a drink of water and she held the glass underneath the tap and poured slowly so that not one drop fell in the sink itself. It wasn't affectation. She did it so casually that I just knew she always did it that way. And when she gave me the glass she held it with a clean napkin. Just hospital-sanitary.

GEORGE: She must be a lot of trouble to herself. Did she agree to come with us right off?

LILLIAN: Well—not right off. She called to her husband about what the weather forecast was, and he said that the newspapers all said it would be fair tomorrow but that he was waiting for the latest report on the radio. Anyway, she called up the weather bureau and had them tell her the latest and she called it out to her husband and they said they'd go, except they said they'd phone us if there were any unexpected changes in the weather.

GEORGE: [To audience] The Sakkaros were young and pleasant, dark and handsome.

LILLIAN: Is that a handbag he's carrying?

GEORGE: Pocket-radio. To listen to weather forecasts, I bet."

LILLIAN: [To audience] It was a beautiful day at Murphy's Park; hot and dry without being too hot; and with a cheerfully bright sun in a blue, blue sky. Even Mr. Sakkaro, though he inspected every quarter of the heavens with a careful eye and then stared piercingly at the barometer, seemed to have no fault to find.

GEORGE: [gloomily] The Sakkaro's went to the refreshment stand. I told them we'd wait here for them.

LILLIAN: Anything wrong?

GEORGE: No, not really, except that I think he must be independently wealthy. I don't know what he does for a living. I hinted— He said he's just a student of human nature. With a handsome, wealthy man next door, it looks as though I'll have impossible standards set for me, too."

LILLIAN: Don't be silly.

GEORGE: And he doesn't come from Arizona. I said I heard he was from Arizona. He looked so surprised, it was obvious he didn't. Then he laughed and asked if he had an Arizona accent.

LILLIAN: He has some kind of accent, you know. There are lots of Spanish-ancestry people in the Southwest, so he could still be from Arizona. Sakkaro could be a Spanish name."

GEORGE: Sounds Japanese to me. —Come on, they're waving. Oh, look what they've bought -- cotton candy,

LILLIAN: [To audience] Huge swirls of pink foam. The Sakkaros held one out to each of us, and out of politeness we accepted. We went down the midway and tried their hand at darts. We took pictures of ourselves. Eventually we collected the youngsters, and the Sakkaros ushered theirs off instantly to the refreshment stand. Tommie hinted the extent of his pleasure at the possible purchase of a hot-dog and George tossed him a quarter. He ran off, too.

GEORGE: Frankly, I prefer to stay here. If I see them biting away at another cotton candy stick I'll turn green and sicken on the spot. If they haven't had a dozen apiece, I'll eat a dozen myself."

LILLIAN: I know, and they're buying a handful for the child now.

GEORGE: I offered Sakkaro a hamburger and he just looked grim and shook his head. Not that a hamburger's much, but after enough cotton candy, it ought to be a feast.

LILLIAN: I know. I offered her an orange drink and the way she jumped when she said no, you'd think I'd thrown it in her face. —Still, I suppose they've never been to a place like this before and they'll need time to adjust to the novelty. They'll fill up on cotton candy and then never eat it again for ten years.

GEORGE: Well, maybe. You know, Lil, it's clouding up. Uh-oh, Sakkaro's seen it. One gets you fifty, he'll want to go home.

LILLIAN: [To audience] All three Sakkaros were polite but insistent. They were sorry, they had had a wonderful time, a marvelous time, the we would have to be their guests as soon as it could be managed, but now, really, they had to go home. It looked stormy. Mrs. Sakkaro wailed that all the forecasts had been for fair weather.

GEORGE: It's hard to predict a local thunderstorm, but even if it were to come, and it mightn't, it wouldn't last more than half an hour on the outside

LILLIAN: [To audience] The Sakkaro youngster seemed on the verge of tears, and Mrs. Sakkaro's hand trembled visibly.

GEORGE: [resigned] Let's go home, [to audience] The drive back seemed to stretch interminably. There was no conversation to speak of. Mr. Sakkaro's radio was quite loud now as he switched from station to station, catching a weather report every time. They were mentioning "local thundershowers" now.

LILLIAN: [brightly] It does look rather threatening, doesn't it? [under her breath] Honestly!

GEORGE: [To audience] A wind had sprung up, driving the dust of the weeks-dry road before it, when we entered our street. The leaves rustled ominously. Lightning flickered. [to Sakkaros] You'll be indoors in two minutes, friends. We'll make it.

LILLIAN: [To audience] George pulled up at the gate that opened onto the Sakkaro's front yard and got out of the car to open the back door. We were just in time.

GEORGE: [To audience] The Sakkaros tumbled out, faces drawn with tension, muttering thanks, and started off toward their long front walk at a dead run.

LILLIAN: Honestly, you would think—"

GEORGE: [to audience] The heavens opened and the rain came down in giant drops as though some celestial dam had suddenly burst. The top of our car was pounded with a hundred drum sticks, and halfway to their front door the Sakkaros stopped and looked despairingly upward. Their faces blurred as the rain hit; blurred and shrank and ran together. All three shriveled, collapsing within their clothes, which sank down into three sticky-wet heaps.

LILLIAN: -- they were made of sugar and afraid they would melt.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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